

NORTHSTAR OUTFITTERS

Returns, Exchanges & Refund Policy

Eligibility, return windows, exchanges, final-sale rules, damaged/wrong items, and refund timing

CUSTOMER SAFE

Version	5.0
Document owner	Customer Policy & Trust
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Purpose	Authoritative customer-facing policy for standard return, exchange, and refund decisions.

Demo environment only. Northstar Outfitters, its customers, products, prices, orders, and commercial terms are fictional and created for SupportOps demonstrations.

Document Control

Audience	Customers and Support
Scope	Return eligibility, 30-day window, condition requirements, exchanges, return shipping responsibility, refunds, wrong/damaged items, and exceptions
Authority	Current authoritative returns policy. Historical tickets and legacy policy documents do not override this document unless a documented exception is approved.
Review cycle	Quarterly or after a material policy/commerce change
Change control	Material changes require owner review and publication before becoming authoritative knowledge.
Knowledge governance Only documents marked PUBLISHED in SupportOps are authoritative for customer-facing answers. Current Shopify catalog, variant, price, availability, cart, and authenticated order state should be obtained from the approved Shopify MCP capability rather than inferred from static documentation.	

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1. Policy Summary

Most eligible Northstar Outfitters items may be returned within 30 calendar days of confirmed delivery. Items must meet the condition requirements in this policy. Exchanges are subject to current stock and are not guaranteed until the replacement is successfully reserved/created.

Current standard return window

30 calendar days from confirmed delivery for eligible items. This is the authoritative current policy for the demo.

2. Return Window

Scenario	Standard eligibility
Request submitted within 30 days of delivery	Potentially eligible if condition requirements are met
Request submitted after 30 days	Outside standard policy; manual exception review may be requested but is not guaranteed
No confirmed delivery event	Use order/fulfillment evidence to establish the applicable timeline
Item arrived wrong/damaged	Use exception handling; report promptly and do not apply change-of-mind shipping rules automatically

3. Eligible Condition

- Item is unworn or unused beyond reasonable try-on.
- Original tags are attached where the product is sold with tags.
- Original product packaging is returned where practical, especially footwear boxes.
- Item is free from customer-caused damage, heavy wear, odor, stains, washing, or modification.
- Proof of purchase/order identity can be verified through the approved commerce system.

4. Footwear Try-On Rules

Footwear may be tried on indoors on a clean surface to assess fit. Outdoor wear, visible outsole abrasion, dirt, trail use, or other signs of use can make a change-of-mind return ineligible.

Condition	Likely handling
Tried indoors, clean outsole, box intact	Eligible within return window
Worn outside briefly, visible outsole marks	May be ineligible as change-of-mind return
Wrong size shipped by Northstar	Merchant-error exception; do not treat as customer-caused wear
Manufacturing defect discovered during first use	Defect process; collect evidence and escalate as needed

5. Apparel and Accessories

Apparel should be unworn except for fit assessment, unwashed, and returned with original tags when supplied. Hygiene-sensitive or specifically marked non-returnable items follow the product-page/checkout disclosure applicable at purchase.

6. Final-Sale Items

Items clearly marked FINAL SALE at the time of purchase are not eligible for change-of-mind returns or exchanges. This restriction does not remove remedies for a wrong item, verified damage, or a genuine product defect.

Do not misuse final-sale rules

A final-sale label is not a reason to reject a legitimate wrong-item or damaged-item case.

7. Exchanges

Size/color exchanges are available for eligible products when the desired replacement variant is currently available. Shopify/current commerce data must be checked before promising an exchange.

1. Confirm original order/item.
2. Confirm return eligibility and item condition expectations.
3. Check desired replacement variant live in Shopify.
4. If available, follow approved exchange workflow.
5. If unavailable, offer refund or other permitted resolution rather than promising future stock.

8. Return Shipping

Reason	Return shipping responsibility
Customer changed mind / ordered wrong size	Customer is normally responsible unless a promotion explicitly provides free returns.
Northstar shipped wrong product/variant	Northstar covers reasonable return/replacement shipping.
Item arrived damaged or verified defective	Northstar covers reasonable return/replacement shipping.
Carrier damage with product impact	Northstar handles customer resolution and may pursue carrier claim separately.

9. Wrong Item

A wrong item means the delivered product or variant does not match the purchased order line. Ask the customer not to use the incorrect item and capture clear product/label evidence where reasonable. Wrong-item cases are merchant-error exceptions and should be escalated through the internal fulfillment workflow if the agent cannot directly resolve them.

10. Damaged or Defective Item

- Ask for photos or description sufficient to understand the issue when practical.
- Separate transit damage from normal wear or customer-caused damage.
- Do not require the customer to perform unsafe testing.
- If a potential safety defect is reported, escalate with high priority and avoid encouraging continued use.

11. Refund Processing

Approved refunds are issued to the original payment method where supported. After the refund is initiated, financial institutions can take additional time to post the credit. A typical customer-facing expectation is 5-10 business days after refund processing, but bank timing is outside Northstar's control.

12. Original Shipping Fees

Original outbound shipping is generally non-refundable for change-of-mind returns. When Northstar is responsible for the error (for example, wrong item or verified defect), Support may include shipping adjustments according to the approved resolution.

13. Late Returns and Exceptions

Requests outside 30 days are not automatically eligible. Support may escalate a documented exception request. Previous one-time exceptions do not create a continuing entitlement and must not be treated as current policy.

Historical-context rule

A previous ticket that approved an exception is evidence of what happened before, not authority to approve the same

exception again.

14. Gift Purchases

Gift returns require sufficient order verification. Refund destination and exchange options depend on the original purchase method and approved workflow. Do not disclose purchaser payment information to an unverified gift recipient.

15. Abuse and Fraud Safeguards

Northstar may review unusual or repeated return patterns. Customer-facing agents should not accuse customers of fraud. If an automated or internal risk control blocks a return, escalate for human review using neutral language.

16. Decision Matrix

Case	Standard answer	Live data required	Escalate when
Unworn shoe, day 12	Eligible if condition met	Order/delivery date	System cannot create return
Unworn shoe, day 38	Outside standard window	Order/delivery date	Customer requests exception
Wrong size shipped	Merchant error; replacement/refund path	Order line + desired variant stock	Replacement workflow fails or repeated fulfillment issue
Desired exchange sold out	Do not promise exchange	Shopify variant availability	Customer requests special alternative
Final-sale item, change of mind	Not eligible	Purchase line/final-sale status	Policy disclosure is disputed
Damaged product	Damage/defect process	Order + evidence	Safety issue or systemic defect

17. FAQ

Q. How long do I have to return an eligible item?

A. 30 calendar days from confirmed delivery.

Q. Can I exchange a shoe for another size?

A. Yes if the original item is eligible and the desired replacement variant is currently available.

Q. Do I pay return shipping?

A. For change-of-mind returns, normally yes. Northstar covers reasonable return shipping for wrong/damaged items.

Q. How long does a refund take?

A. After processing, banks typically take additional time; 5-10 business days is a common expectation in this demo policy.

Q. I got an exception last year. Does it apply again?

A. No. Past exceptions do not replace the current policy; Support can submit a new exception request when appropriate.

Appendix A - Return Inspection Standards

Observation	Change-of-mind interpretation	Exception considerations
Clean, unworn, tags/box present	Normally eligible	None
Minor packaging damage only	Usually assess item condition primarily	Do not reject solely for carrier-damaged outer shipping carton
Footwear outsole visibly worn outdoors	Normally not eligible for change of mind	Could still be wrong-item/defect case
Apparel washed	Normally not eligible for change of mind	Defect claim assessed separately
Product altered/customized by customer	Normally not eligible	Wrong-item/defect facts still reviewed independently

Appendix B - Exchange Edge Cases

Case	Handling
Replacement variant available now	Proceed through approved exchange workflow
Replacement variant sold out	Do not promise future exchange; offer allowed refund/alternative
Price of replacement color differs	Follow exchange configuration/policy; do not manually assume even exchange
Customer wants different product	Treat according to approved return + new purchase/exchange workflow
Original was promotional bundle	Check bundle/discount rules before partial return outcome

Appendix C - Refund Method Examples

Original funding	Expected refund principle
Card	Return to original card/payment route where supported
Gift card	Refund handling follows commerce configuration and original funding rules
Mixed payment	Refund may be split according to platform/payment behavior
Expired/replaced card	Payment network/bank typically routes credit; escalate if refund cannot be completed

Appendix D - Exception Evidence

- Late return: order date, delivery date, reason for delay, item condition, previous commitments if any.
- Wrong item: ordered variant, received item/variant, photos/labels if practical, desired resolution.
- Damaged item: damage description, packaging condition, photos if practical, safety concern indicator.
- Defect: product, use duration, failure description, whether continued use may be unsafe.
- Policy dispute: source/date of customer-facing message or page the customer relied on.

Appendix E - Customer Communication Examples

Situation	Preferred wording direction
Outside window	Your request is outside our standard 30-day return window. I can submit it for manual review, but approval is not guaranteed.
Exchange sold out	That replacement size is not currently available, so I don't want to promise an exchange we cannot fulfill. We can review the available refund/alternative options.
Wrong item	The item you received does not match the ordered variant. We'll treat this as a fulfillment error rather than a change-of-mind return.

Situation	Preferred wording direction
Bank refund delay	The refund has been processed on our side; your bank can take additional business days to post the credit.

Appendix F - Policy Interpretation Edge Cases

Case	Interpretation
Day 30 request submitted before midnight local store policy context	Within standard window if delivery date is correctly established
Day 31 but delivery timestamp was corrected by carrier	Use corrected authoritative delivery date before deciding
Customer started request day 29; label issued day 31	Eligibility is based on timely request/approved workflow, not merely carrier scan of the return
Item part of bundle	Assess discount/bundle impact before partial-return value is finalized
Customer claims policy shown at purchase was different	Capture evidence/source and escalate if current records cannot reconcile the disclosure

Appendix G - Return Lifecycle

6. Return requested and eligibility assessed.
7. Return authorization/label created where applicable.
8. Customer sends item within the required workflow.
9. Return is received and inspected.
10. Exchange/replacement or refund is approved according to outcome.
11. Refund/replacement is created once; duplicate remediation is avoided.
12. Customer receives completion confirmation and bank-posting expectation if refunded.